

Hospitality Perspectives 05

Who stands at the centre of every decision?

Rediscovering The First Principle of Hospitality

“We shape our decisions. Eventually, our decisions shape the experience our guests remember.”

Hospitality has spent decades perfecting the art of measuring performance.

We measure occupancy.

We measure ADR.

We measure RevPAR.

We measure booking pace.

We measure profitability.

We measure customer lifetime value.

These measures are essential. Without them, hotels cannot remain commercially healthy, invest in their people or continue serving their communities. Commercial discipline is not the enemy of hospitality—it is one of its greatest enablers.

Yet perhaps we have become so accomplished at measuring performance that we have forgotten to ask one simple question.

Who stands at the centre of every decision?

For many years our industry has proudly declared that *the guest comes first*. It is a wonderful principle.

But principles only become meaningful when they guide the decisions we make every single day.

Perhaps it is time to ask a different question.

Not...

“How do we maximise guest value?”

But rather...

“How do we maximise the value we create for the guest?”

At first glance the difference appears subtle.

In reality, it changes everything.

The first question quietly places the guest inside a commercial calculation.

The second places the guest at the very heart of hospitality.

A Moment We Cannot Measure

Imagine a guest arriving on a cold, rainy afternoon.

Their coat is soaked.

Their umbrella is dripping.

They have travelled for hours and simply want to feel that they have arrived somewhere safe.

Before a room is allocated...

Before a payment is processed...

Before a single KPI changes...

Hospitality has already begun.

Someone smiles.

Someone offers to take their coat.

Someone finds a place for their umbrella.

Someone offers a warm cup of tea or coffee while check-in is completed.

Someone remembers their name.

None of these moments appear on a dashboard.

Yet these are often the moments guests remember years after they have forgotten the room number they stayed in or the rate they paid.

The transaction will eventually be forgotten.

The feeling of being genuinely welcomed rarely is.

The First Principle of Hospitality

From that simple observation, a principle emerges.

Hospitality begins when we place the guest—not the transaction, not the technology, not the process and not even ourselves—at the centre of every decision.

This principle does not diminish the importance of commerce.

Quite the opposite.

Commerce makes hospitality sustainable.

Technology makes hospitality possible.

Leadership gives hospitality direction.

Operations deliver hospitality consistently.

Data helps us understand.

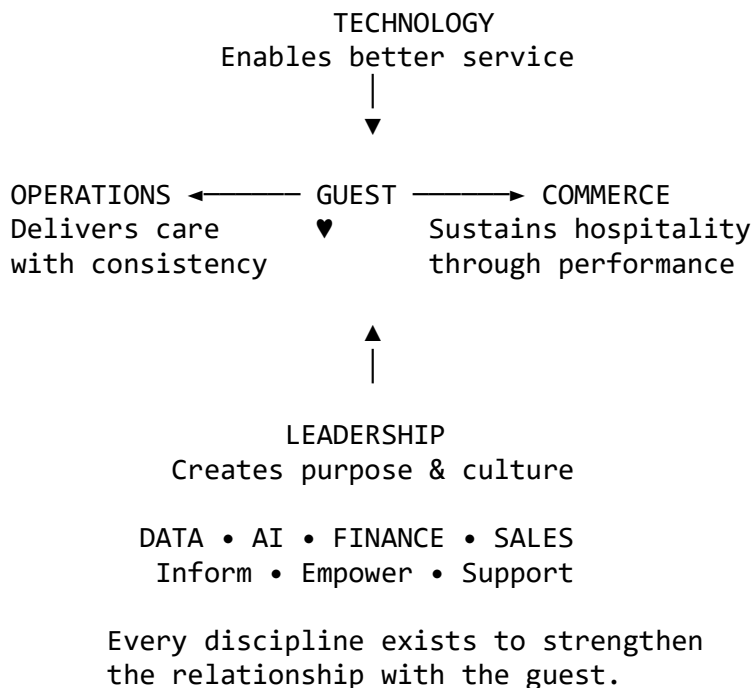
Artificial Intelligence helps us work more efficiently.

Every one of these disciplines matters.

But they all exist for the same purpose.

To help people care for people.

The Hospitality Framework



Hospitality Is Never a Solo Performance

Exceptional hospitality is rarely the achievement of one outstanding individual.

It is the result of many people working together with one shared purpose.

Reception welcomes.

Housekeeping prepares.

Engineering quietly ensures comfort.

Food and Beverage creates memorable experiences.

Revenue and Commercial teams provide the financial strength that allows investment in people and service.

Technology removes unnecessary friction.

Leadership brings everyone together around a common purpose.

No department succeeds alone.

If one part of the guest journey loses sight of the guest, the entire experience is affected.

The finest hospitality teams understand something remarkably simple.

They approach their work with humility.

They listen.

They support one another.

They willingly place the success of the guest experience above personal recognition.

Like children working together naturally toward a shared goal, they understand that belonging is created collectively, never individually.

Guests do not experience departments.

They experience one hotel.

The Executive Test

Before introducing a new technology, ask:

Will it help our people care for the guest better?

Before approving a commercial strategy, ask:

Will it strengthen the relationship with our guests?

Before redesigning a process, ask:

Will it make the guest's experience simpler, warmer or more personal?

Before analysing data, ask:

What is this helping us understand about our guests—not just our performance?

Before implementing Artificial Intelligence, ask:

Will this give our people more time to be present with the guest?

Before making a financial decision, ask:

Will this investment improve the guest experience over the long term?

Before making a leadership decision, ask:

Will this help our teams care for people with greater confidence, purpose and pride?

A Different Measure of Success

Perhaps the future of hospitality will not belong to the organisations with the most sophisticated technology.

Nor simply to those with the most advanced commercial systems.

It will belong to those who never forget why those tools exist in the first place.

Technology should never replace hospitality.

It should remove distractions from it.

Commerce should never replace relationships.

It should sustain them.

Leadership should never seek recognition.

It should create the conditions in which others can succeed.

When every decision is guided by the same principle, something remarkable begins to happen.

The guest no longer feels like another reservation.

They feel recognised.

They feel respected.

They feel that they belong.

And when people feel they belong, they often choose to return—not because they were persuaded by marketing, but because they remember how they were made to feel.

Tomorrow morning, before opening another dashboard...

Before reviewing another forecast...

Before approving another investment...

Pause for a moment.

Ask one simple question.

Does this help us care for the guest better?

If the answer is yes...

Continue.

If the answer is no...

Perhaps the decision deserves another conversation.

Because hospitality has never truly been about managing transactions.

It has always been about caring for people.

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